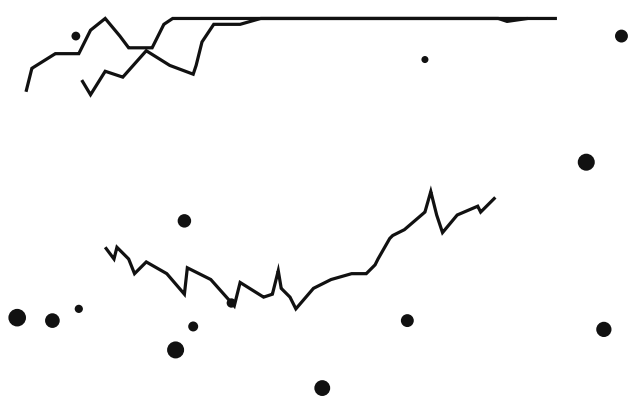
Papier Bleu

No. 49 · January 2019

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No. 49

JANUARY 2019

PROSE POETRY

PAPIER BLEU

No. 49 · January 2019

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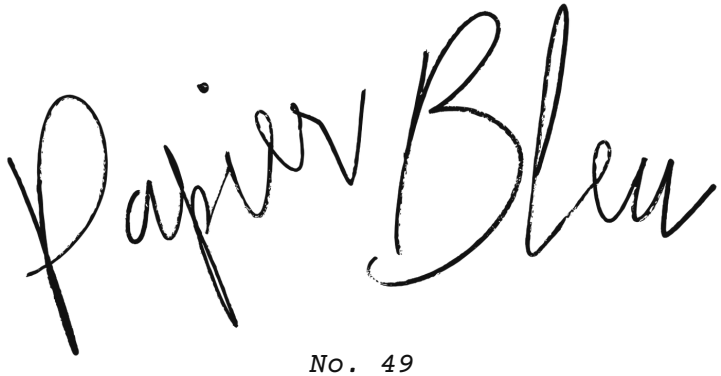
Ingrid U. (Lund Univ.) has one word of Finnish and uses it every Saturday.

Maja A. (Uppsala Univ.) has lived in Uppsala for four winters and counts them.

Freja S. (Lund Univ.) studies medicine in Lund and goes home to Copenhagen on weekends.

Emil B. (Lund Univ.) draws orienteering maps for a club in Skåne.

Ebba A. (Lund Univ.) grew up on a lake in Värmland and knows the ice by its names.



No. 49

JANUARY 2019

Ten writers on the second language

MASTHEAD

Founder & Editor-in-Chief

Kristil Rabideau

Papier Bleu is an independent student magazine. It is not an official publication of Uppsala University, and the views expressed belong to the writers.

Contributors are listed on pages 17 and 18.

CONTRIBUTORS

Tove E. (Uppsala Univ.) studies linguistics in Uppsala and walks the fields past the last bus stop.

Astrid J. (Uppsala Univ.) is a physics student who measures winter in minutes of daylight.

Saga N. (Stockholm Univ.) spends her summers at her grandmother’s lake in Dalarna.

Wilma U. (Stockholm Univ.) teaches English to her grandmother and learns Swedish again.

Nils U. (Stockholm Univ.) grew up on subtitled television and is studying law.

ICE, THICKENING

Ebba A. · Lund Univ.

4 cm. Nyis. New ice, black as a window at night. It sings when a stone skips across it, a long falling whistle like a wire drawn through water. Lie down on the shore with your ear to it: it ticks.

9 cm. Kärnis. Clear enough to see the weed standing up in it and the bubbles caught on their way up, white beads, a necklace dropped through. It holds you. Underfoot, a long low groan.

14 cm. Råk. A crack running out from the point, a black lip of water in it, steaming. Farfar taps the edge with his ice pick and says the word twice, the way you say a dog's name to make it sit.

20 cm. Skates. The blades bite with a sound of tearing silk, the ice claws knock at your collarbone, wind fills your sleeves, and the bay is a gray floor with the dark backs of pike drifting under your feet.

26 cm. Stöpis. Snow gone to slush and frozen again, white and pocked as old soap. Someone has set a table out on it, a candle in a jar, blackcurrant in paper cups that burn through the mitten.

April. Issörja. The bay gone to gray slush, grinding at the reeds. Take the ice off the front of the word and what is left means to grieve. He taught me that one too, at the kitchen window, watching it go out.

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INTERESTED IN SUBMITTING?

Send works no longer than 500 words, in the form of prose poetry. If you are looking for clarity, the best example is Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities*, or this issue.

Send your work to rabideaukristil@gmail.com.

Please title your email "Papier Bleu Submission" for easy finding.

LEGEND

Emil B. · Lund Univ.

Cut from the bottom of an orienteering map of the forest above Klippan, scale 1:10 000. My father kept the rest.

(o) boulder, over 1 m. South face warm
into October.
(^) root plate. Spruce, the January storm.
Holds its own earth up in the air.
(x) charcoal-burning ground. Black under
the moss. Scrape it: soot.
(~) marsh, passable. Cotton grass, water
to the knee. Smells like a cellar.
(#) ruined wall. Sheep-high. Nobody's.
(.) control. Orange and white. Hung
where he said it would be.

He read maps the way other men read the paper. Sundays he did both, at the kitchen table, moving his lips. I got the legend. The part that says what everything means. He kept the part that says where.

DECLARATION AT HYLLIE

Freja S. · Lund Univ.

IDENTITY CHECK, HYLLIE STATION. DECLARATION.

Name: as my mother says it in Valby, short, like a door closing, and as the conductor says it after Hyllie, the vowel pulled long like toffee. Both correct. Neither asked.

Address: Lund: a room, a radiator that ticks, a window on the cathedral. Weekends: my mother's flat over the bakery on Valby Langgade, stairwell smelling of yeast and wet umbrellas.

Purpose of journey: anatomy, Tuesdays. A dentist. A boy in Malmö who says Danish isn't a language, it's a throat disease, and kisses me anyway.

Language spoken at home: Danish until the bridge. Swedish after. In between, for the few minutes over the water when the train comes up out of the tunnel into all that light: whatever my mouth is doing.

Goods to declare: one jar of my mother's remoulade, wrapped in a scarf. You may not have it.

At Hyllie a policeman shines a torch on my face, then on my card, then, for reasons he keeps to himself, on my hands.

UPPLAND, OCTOBER

Tove E. · Uppsala Univ.

A note on the definite article. In Swedish it comes at the end, so a thing becomes the thing by growing a tail. *Åker*, a field. *Åkern*, the field: this one, past the last stop of the country bus, plowed in long clay furrows that shine where the blade turned them and smell of cellar and cold iron. *Sten*, a stone. *Stenen*, the stone: one of the thousand in the cairn at the field's edge, where farmers have piled what the frost pushes up every spring since the Vikings. *Lada*, a barn. *Ladan*, the barn, Falu red, which comes off chalky on your sleeve. *Trana*, a crane. *Tranorna*, the cranes, three hundred of them in the stubble, creaking like hinges. And by the road, behind a wire and a snapping orange ribbon, a runestone that says Ulf had this raised for Gunnar, his brother. *Bror*, a brother. *Brodern*, the brother. A cow is scratching her neck on the serpent carved around his name. I have the nouns now, and the endings. The verbs are still on their way. Until they come, nothing in this country does anything. It only is, with its tail on: *åkern, stenen, brodern*.

SIX HOURS OF DAYLIGHT

Astrid J. · Uppsala Univ.

From the back pages of a lab notebook, Ångström Laboratory, Uppsala.

9 Jan. Sunrise 08:44. Sunset 15:08. Daylight 6 h 24 min, gaining approx. 3 min/day. Max. solar elevation 8°. At noon my shadow is seven times my height.

Obs. 1. Studded tires on Kungsgatan: sound comparable to bacon in a pan. At −12 °C the hairs in the nostrils freeze on the first breath. n = 1.

Obs. 2. Fyris freezing from the banks inward. Center open: black, fast, steaming. Forty mallards on the shelf ice, all facing SW. Wind SW. They face into it so it can't lift their feathers.

Obs. 3. 15:40. Dark, all at once. In every window on the street the same seven-armed electric candlestick comes on. Mine too. I do not remember deciding this.

Obs. 4. I think in physics, a cold language and a kind one. I dream in my mother's Swedish, which is all arguments, vowels slamming like cupboard doors.

Sun., call w/ M. 11 min. In English, because English is where we are polite. Reported: the candles. Omitted: everything else.

Conclusion. They leave them on all night.

FOUR WINTERS

Maja A. · Uppsala Univ.

The first winter, I woke in a room with a window and a lamp and had no word for either. On the stairs every morning a woman in a fur hat said two words to me, and I smiled at her as if she had handed me something to hold.

The second winter, I woke in a rum with a fönster and a lampa, and the woman on the stairs said *kallt idag*, and I knew it meant cold today, and I said yes, in English, and she nodded as if that would do for now.

The third winter, I vaknade in a rum with a fönster, och the natt was lång, och the snö squeaked under my boots like polystyrene, och on the stairs fru Berg said *kallt idag*, och I said *ja, kallt*, och she stopped on the landing to look at me.

Den fjärde vintern vaknade jag i mitt rum, vid mitt fönster, och nattens ljus var snö. I trappan mötte jag fru Berg i pälsmössan. Jag sa det först.

SATURDAY, BASTU

Ingrid U. · Lund Univ.

Saturday. The lake. The bastu: a hut tarred black,
a stove of river stones, birch smoke in the
rafters, the door swollen with damp, shouldered
open. Morfar, who came from Finland in 1969 to weld
ships at Kockums, and who speaks Swedish
everywhere but here.

FIRST BENCH
  planks cool under the thighs,
  Morfar in Swedish: the weather
    SECOND BENCH
    hair lifting on the arms,
    birch smoke, tar, his Swedish
    thinning with the air
        THIRD BENCH
        a ladle on the stones, a sheet
        torn in half, the heat laid flat
        on the crown of the head, and he
        says something in Finnish
            TOP BENCH
            ears ringing, eyelids hot as coins,
            salt at the corners of the mouth,
            and his one word that I have:
            löyly, the steam off the stones,
            the old word for a soul

Then: door, dock, black lake. A cold with no
temperature in it. The body shouts once, no sound,
comes up pink and new. Snow melting on our
shoulders. Morfar in to the chin, steaming like a
horse, saying, in Swedish: lovely. Come in.

FARMOR'S LAKE

Saga N. · Stockholm Univ.

Farmor, your lake is the color of tea left too long
in the pot, warm as bathwater on top and cold a
foot down, where the light goes brown and my feet
go white. Your dock is silver and full of splinters
and in July too hot to stand on, so I dance, and
you laugh at me from the porch over your coffee.
You and Farfar carried the stones for the cabin up
from the shore in 1961, and you mention it about as
often as the weather, which is always. You clean
perch on yesterday's *Dala-Demokraten* with a knife
you've sharpened down to a leaf, and the scales fly
up and stick to your forearms like sequins, and you
talk the whole time in älvdalska, the Swedish of
your valley, which the rest of Sweden can't follow
and neither can I. It sounds like Swedish heard
through water. One sound comes through: a soft th,
the th from my English class, which Swedish put
down centuries ago and you kept, the way you keep
string, and butter papers, and me. When I come in
with my mouth red from lingonberries you ask me
something, and I say ja, and you laugh until you
have to hold the table, and pour.

ENGLISH, AS SHE WILL HEAR IT

Wilma U. · Stockholm Univ.

For my grandmother, who flies to Minneapolis on Thursday. Spelled the way her ear will hear it. Read aloud exactly as written.

Aj äm fråm Sviiden.

Maj sister livs in Minneåpolis. Shi kejm hiir in najntiin-fiffti-tuu.

Nåu, aj häv nå frut. Ånli knäckebröd.

Plis spiik slåuli. Aj äm åld.

Hau mötch is datt?

Ekskjus mi. Uer is ruum tu-fårtiin?

Nörs, shi is spiiking Svidish. Aj kän önderständ her.

She practiced the last one most: on the cat, on the kettle, on the bus, on me.

SUBTITLES

Nils U. · Stockholm Univ.

Okay. So here's the deal. In Sweden we don't dub. We let the Americans talk and put our language underneath in two white lines with a black edge, and that is how my whole generation learned English: in the blue light on the ceiling after bedtime, from cops. By eight I knew that *Freeze!* is *Stå still!* and that *honey* is a word for your wife, or for a guy you are about to shoot. Friday nights the whole building went quiet for the show where the detective in Miami takes off his sunglasses before he says anything important, and through the wall, over the smell of Mrs. Lindqvist's cardamom buns, you could hear her reading the subtitles out loud half a second ahead of the actors, like she knew something. A woman could say *I love you* three ways with the same mouth, and the subtitle had room for one. Copy that. I learned the room. So when I finally get to London and open my mouth in a shop on the Strand, out comes this perfect American sentence, and the girl at the till looks down, real slow, at the bottom of my face.